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Alicia Olatuja

Vocalist/composer Alicia Olatuja has excelled in a variety of musical genres. She received a master's degree in classical voice from the Manhattan School of Music, while performing jazz and Gospel music with artists like Chaka Kahn and the Brooklyn Tabernacle Choir. Her first solo album is the 2014 release "Timeless."

Alicia was interviewed in Clinton, New York on February 9, 2018 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have Alicia Olatuja for us, for the Fillius Jazz Archive. Welcome to Hamilton.

AO: Thank you for having me.

MR: And congratulations on your career so far.

AO: Oh, thank you. I have a great team of people and one of the members of my team is right there, Miles Weinstein, and I have a great band and we all work together. We're like a team and we just push each other forward.

MR: You anticipated a question.

AO: Oops.

MR: But first I just want to say you are one of the few people I've met who went from a Mozart opera to Dr. Lonnie Smith. Does it seem like a leap or not?

AO: Well I think I was exposed to soul music before I was doing Mozart. So in my brain it wasn't a leap because all the music is always playing. But I would see how on a resume that might look a little interesting, yeah.

MR: Does the drama involved in being in an opera inform you on stage now?

AO: Well I mean I feel like performers and singers in general do have an element of drama just built into their DNA. I mean for us to be communicators we are like the griots of this generation. We are the storytellers. We're the ones who take you on a journey. And if you've ever worked with a group of 5-year-old children and try to tell them a story, you just take those exact same skills and, you know, they're not thinking about bills and FaceBook. So imagine how much more distracted like the average adult audience is — so you just have to take that same energy and tell the same story. And it requires you to be animated and requires you to believe in what you're saying and speak with courage and conviction. And I think that goes for if you're just standing in front of a roomful of people talking, like now, or singing on stage. It's all about communication I think. Not so much the drama, but communicating.

MR: I shared something with you that we both did and that is being a teaching artist. Is that amazing work?

AO: I love it. Well I've been told that teaching is in my blood. My mother is a teacher, my grandmother was a teacher, an educator, a professor, but also a nurse. And she was a head nurse to teach other nurses. And education is just really important. It was important to me. It changed my life. And I really love watching that moment when things click, and even helping someone through when you're hitting that wall. And it's just like uh — and we all experience that every day with something, especially if we're brave enough to try to get better at something. So I like being a part of that.

MR: Did you have sort of an aha moment as a youth with a recording or something in church?

AO: More oh no, than aha. But I will say that I think aha moments come when you realize that someone believes in you. I think that was my aha moment. And you kind of just put together a bunch of different aha moments until you actually say okay, this is what I'm going to do. So I'd say my first aha moment was when I was in kindergarten and they used to play "The Star Spangled Banner" over the intercom. And I would stand up and just be like so proud. And we could sing along if we wanted to, and I sang along, real strong. And my teacher, Mrs. Marge, I still remember her, I can't find her but I've been looking, Mrs. Marge if you're out there —

MR: Well spell it and maybe it will help.

AO: I don't know how to spell it. I was five. I don't know how to — but it was Mrs. Marge and she pulled me aside and she was like, "Alicia, I'm going to tell you something." She was like, "You're not going to know what this means right now, but one day you're going to understand." And I was like, "What's that Miss Marge." I thought I was in trouble. She said, "One day you are going to be a great singer. But remember, do not get the big head." And I was like my head's going to get — I mean I thought she meant like hydrocephaly, like I was going to — but she was like, "I know you don't understand right now but you will." And in a sense it was like that was the first person who told me, basically they hear something. To hear something in my voice. To hear something that has potential for something. And it's not so much always that you realize it about yourself because sometimes that takes, that to me is almost like another journey. Self-acceptance as an artist and what you hear, but to actually be told this is something that is a great possibility for your life, at such a young age, you know it put that little light bulb on to say oh, okay. Maybe she knows something I don't know. Which obviously she did.

MR: That's terrific. Have you developed sort of an inner alarm when something comes, an opportunity in your career and you feel like tempted to do it and then say wait a minute, let me think about this.

AO: Oh man, see I'm not good at that. That's why I have to have a team to help me. Because I'm always like — my philosophy, even when I was in school when I was singing and performing, was to say yes to everything. I really think you should say yes to as much as you possibly can. Because there's so many opportunities that you want that someone's going to say no to. Someone else is going to be the gatekeeper of that opportunity. So if you can do something, just do it. Even if you don't know if you could do it, do it. I've had people say, "Oh I would have done this gig but I don't do that type of music." I'm like, "You should say yes and then learned it really quickly and then did the gig." You have to just say yes. You have to do as much yes-yes-yes as you possibly can until you really cannot say yes. Until you have a conflict. Until you feel like you know what, I don't think that this is a part of what my mission is. I don't think that this is the direction in which I want to go. But ultimately I'm more of a just say yes to everything unless you feel like it's going to take away from another yes.

MR: If you try to do everything do you risk not having an identity in the music business?

AO: Nope. That's a good question. That's such a good question, and it's something that I have had to answer and ask and question other people about since I was a freshman in college. And it's been very interesting. I spoke with like this really amazing opera diva extraordinaire, and I said to her, you know, can I take classical technique and just learn how to work my instrument and then like sing in any genre I want? And she looked at me up and down. She was like, "I have no idea what you're talking about." Then she like flung her scarf and walked out the room all dramatic. And I was like, "Really?" And then I spoke with the music history professor, Dr. Budds, he's actually quite brilliant. And I said to him, "You know, I love all different types of music and I feel like I'm being informed by all different types of genres. Do I have to pick one and shut the door on all these other ones. It makes me feel like I'm at a buffet and I'm just determined to eat the pasta." And he said to me, he was like, "You know what? Just try to be good at one thing and then build on that." But he said, "You can't be bad at everything or mediocre at a bunch of things." He said, "Really figure out what it requires to be excellent at something and then use that same method to be excellent at more and more things." He was like, "And then you know whatever. People are way more forgiving and open to an artist who has already shown that they're willing to be dedicated to an art form and really pour themselves into it and then transfer to other genres."

MR: Do you think it's harder to rise up in the hierarchy in the opera world or in the jazz world?

AO: You know, it depends. It just depends on your opportunities, it depends on your dedication, it depends on your voice. I don't mean like how good or bad you are, I mean like a soprano's chances are not as easy as a bass baritone for instance. Just getting into a

conservatory, most of the scholarships go to the men because there's less of them. So I was told like for every four sopranos they hear one mezzo. For every four mezzos it's one tenor. For ever four tenors it's one bass. And so there were guys who had not spent as much time as the soprano had, working on this and working on that. But she didn't get the scholarship you know. He got the scholarship and he was like, "Oh no, I think I want to do singing or maybe football." Like he wasn't even you know, serious about what he was doing. But he had a beautiful voice but they needed these male singers so badly that, you know, there were so many sopranos that were rejected and therefore it will impact their chances at success. But I think, you know, it all depends on where you go after that, what you do with the opportunities that you have. I've seen people take an opportunity that people would laugh at and turn that thing into gold. And I've seen people take these platinum opportunities and just squander, you know? So I think it depends on the individual, it depends on the opportunities, and then what you do with those opportunities. And I think that applies for both classical and jazz. And then it's about what do you consider success to be?

MR: When I was in college, and all us guys who wanted to "make it" in the music business. And I don't even think we really knew, well what does that mean? We want to make it. Does that have a —

AO: Oh yeah, that's like making it. Ooh that's such a good one. These are really good questions, by the way. I'm enjoying these questions.

MR: Well maybe we should cancel your concert and just keep talking.

AO: Do I still get the check at the end? Just want to know.

MR: That's good business.

AO: I'll work on that. What is interesting, making it means many different things to many different people. I think you have to figure out what making it means to you and not what making it looks like to somebody else, or what somebody tells you making it means. For some people it's just being debt free. You're already, how much percentage of America is in debt first of all. So if you could just be debt free you are up in the higher percentage, upper echelon of like Americans and their finances. So maybe that's somebody's idea of making it. Somebody else's idea of making it, a dear friend of mine was that she said she want to be a professional singer but I also want to be married and have kids. Like I don't want to have to choose. And so she did that. And there was a season that was really, really tricky for her, but she made it work. And she's, I don't know, a superwoman. But that is her idea of success. Other people it's to travel around the world and have no strings attached anywhere. To be able to pick up and go whenever I want and not have to answer to anybody and not have to worry about where I'm going to live and not have to — not, I know I can go to Spain and find an apartment, and if I get tired — like that's

their idea. Not everybody wants to be Beyoncé. Not everybody even should be, oh my God. You know? So there's many different ideas of success and I think the sad part is that a lot of times people feel pressure to become as successful as other people say they should be. And success is so many different things. There are people that I never knew of until I got into the world of jazz. Never heard their name, I didn't even know they existed. And then, but that doesn't mean that they weren't successful until I discovered who they were. It's ridiculous. They were already Grammy award winners, they had houses in foreign countries and houses in America. They could go anywhere they want. They only do a few performances a year and they're loaded. And I had no idea who they were. Does that mean they're not successful, because they're not worldwide household name like Michael Jackson? No. And look what happened to him.

MR: Yeah. Okay. I want to Name that Alicia tune.

AO: Oh. Who plays this, me or the —

MR: It's right there.

AO: Oh God, are you doing this to me? These are the students, they should be sight reading.

MR: Well this thing has been stuck in my head.

AO: This looks like "Truth in Blue."

MR: Yes it is.

AO: Okay.

MR: So I wanted to — you passed the audition.

AO: Oh God.

MR: I wanted to ask you about that note.

AO: Um hum.

MR: [hums] like that half step there.

AO: Um hum.

MR: Wow. My ears were expecting an F sharp I guess. Do you remember that?

AO: Well there's more to that. That's actually the piece of another story. In the very beginning it has the melody [hums]. And then comes that line [hums]. So that's the whole arc. And the arc tells a story. So in the very beginning there are those three lines, right? And what happened for me is that I kept hearing those three lines playing in my head over and over and over again, like for months. It was crazy. And I felt like the notes had a story but I had to try to figure it out or else I couldn't write the rest of the song. So then when I sat down with the melody and I thought oh my goodness, all of a sudden it made sense to me. The melody starts the same but the ending has slight variations. And the first line basically represented we are starting a relationship. It doesn't necessarily mean that it's romantic. It can be. But it can be friendship. At the time it was friendship for me. And you start it and it doesn't quite work out the way you want it to, but it's not bad, it just

didn't, you know, something went — and then you try it again and then it really goes left on you. And that's when you maybe have the bad break-up. And then you have the third time, you try it again, and then there's [hums] and what you have is like a moment of acceptance, where it resolves. And then the line [hums] is just whatever the next phase in life is but it keeps playing over and over again until you find the solution that you have to accept. And so the song is called "Truth In Blue" because you hear about white lies and you hear about bad lies, there's all these different shades of what a lie is. But ultimately a lie is a lie. And I believe the same thing applies to truth. We try to come up with all these different versions of truth. "Oh maybe, I don't know, I mean it could have worked out but maybe it was just —" and you know you make all these excuses because we don't want to accept the truth about something, because the truth is just, we cannot feel resolution in that. We are not satisfied with it. But the thing is until you accept the truth about something you will continue to repeat it over and over again, regardless if that truth is something that you want to accept or not. You will continue to experience it. And you will never feel rest. And so that's why that note does that. And that's why the song ends with that as well. Because at the end of the song we don't know if I've gotten it yet. So that's what that is. That seems a bit brainy but, not all songs are like that.

MR: That's a great backstory to that. Anyway and I love the way the song just starts out with just you and there's nothing like a little bit of something to listen to to capture your attention, at least that's the way I feel. What's going to come next, as opposed to everybody starting together.

AO: Yeah. One-two-one-pow.

MR: Do you — I have to take a few questions here but I just wonder do you ever, in collaborating with your band mates, have to say, "What is that chord?" I know you're trying something over there, maybe not that.

AO: Well usually if we're arranging together I like to give my band a lot of freedom. I actually don't like to control. Even if I feel uncomfortable a little bit. But sometimes it's okay, as an artist, to feel uncomfortable and to figure out how to make this thing work. I mean if they go really strong left and I'm like that is horrible. But they don't usually do that. They are very very musical people and very very musical musicians. So usually they're going to make a choice and it makes some sort of sense. But there are times I've had to like wrangle them like just for the sake of time, "Like look, we got half an hour to arrange this song, we're running out of time, I gotta pay up at the desk, can we just figure — just do a pedal, just do a pedal and do whatever chords you want to do on top of the pedal." Like I've had to do that. But I don't like to rein in their creativity because I feel like I still want to learn. I still want to grow. And this is, even though yes, it's my face and my name on the poster, for me it never feels like the Alicia Olatuja show. It feels like

this is a chance for all of us to listen to each other and try to push it a little bit. And sometimes I do feel uncomfortable and I have to really take a minute and try to decide, do I really want to change that or not. Do I really need to change it? Or should I just let it sit for a while and see what happens?

MR: Yeah because it might not be played the same the next time it comes around anyway.

AO: Right, right. I'm way more specific with vocals. Like if I have background — I usually have like incredible additional vocalists with me and I have great voices in the band. But usually with them, that's when I get like really like — because there's something specific that they have to communicate. And they have to function as instruments, not necessarily as a human. They have to almost function as a string instrument. So if they want to do something like really funky I'm like, "Save that for that other song, not there please."

MR: I see. Do we have a question from the audience? Someone want to ask?

XX: Yes, I'm just curious, do you ever take, do you ever look at like contemporary artists and like incorporate bits into your own style from even household names like Beyoncé like you mentioned?

AO: Well I mean it's great that you mention that because the next album that I just recorded is actually called "Intuition, Songs from the Minds of Women" and it's celebrating and championing women composers. And I use, I collected a bunch of different songs from women composers of all the genres and backgrounds, from Joni Mitchell to Imogen Heap to Sade, to my student. Like, as well as my own songs as well. But I think hearing the through line of the experience, the human experience is what I'm really going after. I'm really trying to capture that. Because music is all about unifying us above our race and religion and political point of views, and I think that can't be boxed in a genre and you can't say I refuse to be influenced by this person, because they, whatever reason. So I'm influenced by a lot of different musicians and artists and I'm going to do one of those tunes tonight so hopefully you'll recognize it. But anyway, it's a different arrangement but it's pretty cool.

MR: Yeah I was just listening to your version of "Somewhere Over the Rainbow." Where do you come up with that?

AO: Well I actually — half of it a friend of mine, Christian Sands, he had arranged that for his trio. And it was just the same eight bars that were looping. And I was like, "Oh how lovely." But it was just the song [sings] it was not the [sings] some day I wish upon a star. So then we sat down and I said you know I really want to do that part of the song but we have to build to that. I can't just do nothing for eight bars. And then I really wanted to stretch the line and stretch the text. And yeah, we just kind of made it flow, and yeah, I really like it. It's a tough sing, I like it.

MR: A tough sing. I like that phrase.

XX: I think music these days has become a lot more electronic and processed, and there are a lot of artists who are staying true to their sound and staying raw with acoustic instruments and voices without a lot of digital manipulation. Where do you think music is headed in that regard? Do you think that there's going to be a revival of the classic band sound? Or what do you think?

AO: Well I think the world of music is big, and I think there's room for all of it. I don't think it's really the musicians or the artists that are making it marginalized, I think it's the music industry that's telling people what they want to hear. And I think also the music industry isn't about music. Not pop music, and not a lot, just the music industry in general — most industries and businesses are just about money anyway. So it's our responsibility as the artist to push as much through that. And now we have the ability to do that because we can put a studio in our house and we can go on Kickstarter and raise money, we can get our friends together and record an album. We don't need the machines everybody else needed. But I think music becoming more technological is just a part of the evolution of technology and art. You see that in all forms of art. You see it in movement. You see it in paintings, you see it in installations. Technology has a way of painting all parts of our society. The issue is when the musicians who don't want to do that aren't offered the same opportunities. And I think that's where we have to rally together and start those underground movements, where a lot of great musicians started anyway, back in the day. They were underground. They didn't have like YouTube and FaceBook to just blow up overnight. Nobody was really was really blowing up overnight back in the day. And I also think the live music experience can never be duplicated unless you're there. So I feel like what will last beyond everything else will be how it began, just the person and you guys. That's really what it is. For me it's even — like I don't really rely too much on — I listen to the monitors only because I feel like when everything else is happening and all the other monitors are coming up, it kind of makes the sound weird for me because I come from the classical background where there was just you and the piano and you just stand there and let it happen. There's something magical and something very organic about that which is why I think that genre of classical music has been able to stay alive. But I think that's what will always continue to make itself present. People will go to shows, pop shows now, and they're like, "She was terrible" like they're so disappointed. I'm like well what did you think was going to happen, everything she sings is like [babbles] like that's what the album was, like why are you mad. Because they don't sound like that. People still want to feel like they're looking at and communicating and connecting with a human. So I think we will never be able to get away from that. But I think we as artists, we have to just stick to that. We could do a couple stuff here and there. There's room for it all. But don't let go of what

you know is real music, and respect your art form enough to spend time on it to make it right. To sharpen it. Notice, no violinists are getting away with that.

MR: They have to play in tune.

AO: They have to play.

MW: I wanted to ask this question. As you go through your singing career, sometimes without even making a obvious attempt to do it, your music takes on a certain cultural significance. And I wanted to ask you if you have a song in your repertoire that you think already fits this or will you have an aha moment when that moment comes? For instance. It's 1963 and Sam Cooke sings "A Change is Gonna' Come." It may as well be an African-American national anthem.

AO: Right.

MW: You know what I'm saying? Everybody knows it. So I was coaching a girl, she was 17 years old, she was singing for an NAACP convention. And me and another one of the coaches said, and it was all going to be older black people. And we said if you sing this song right there won't be a dry eye in the auditorium. And she rocked the house. So at that moment she absorbed the history of that song. It transferred into her. She realized she wasn't just singing a melody. You know what I mean? Do you already have a song in your repertoire that's something of that cultural validity of power or authority, or will you know that aha moment when you got one.

AO: I think it really depends on the audience first of all. I mean you know if you're singing for a group of children, they're just, their aha is very different. I think I've had several different aha moments singing different pieces. One of the aha moments that I always feel very connected to is when, on, well some of the tunes that we sing have a different impact, but sometimes I actually do an encore. I don't know if I'll do one today, because usually it's whatever the audience wants. But when we do the encore and when I sing in another configuration program called Songs of Freedom, which celebrates songs of Nina Simone, Abbey Lincoln and Joni Mitchell. One of the tunes that I feel really resonates with me today as much as it did when it was written, is "Everything Must Change." And when I sing that it's almost a bittersweetness. Because you realize how much has not changed and how much can change. So there's that hope that we can still move forward but we have to acknowledge where we're failing in progression. So I feel like that becomes like a very aha type of moment. But in the same sense I feel, like I was just talking to Miles in the band about this today, I did a piece with Billy Childs and it was about human sex trafficking like just a heavy topic but something that you can't ignore. And we performed it at Michigan State. And when I was learning the piece and watching all these films trying to just get into the mindset, I was like oh God this is just so heartbreaking. I wasn't thinking about the aha. I was just trying to really make this

authentic for me. But when I performed the piece and I was sitting, performing in front of rows and rows of survivors, as well as the police department that actually specializes in these rescue missions, then the aha moment was there. And that's because of who was there. You know I think aha moments can be personal, but they can also be a collective experience. And I think the one that I feel like you're speaking of in particular is the magical aha moments that happen in the collective experience of performance, which is mind-blowing. I think that's really powerful and it can change both the audience member and the artist.

MR: Good answer. I know you have a performance.

AO: Oh, that.

MR: And maybe we'll wrap up. What do you hope that the audience leaves with in their head about you after the concert tonight?

AO: Well to me it's not so much what they'll leave about me. Like I don't feel like it's really about me. I think I want them to leave with the feeling that lasts beyond what they thought about what I wore or whether my feet hurt in those shoes. They will be hurting in those shoes. But I want people to leave with the feeling, feeling connected to the person that sat behind them and that sat next to them. And I want people to remember that you know in the big grand scheme of things, the little things don't really matter, but the simple things do. And simple things can be profound as well as considered small. So that's what I want to happen. I would rather somebody hear a song and be like, "You know what? Maybe things aren't so bad. Maybe I should just go home. Or maybe I should just take that job. Or maybe I should just, maybe I should just go ahead and choose that career choice. When am I so afraid of? I'd rather they had that experience than what they thought about me. Because I'm just the messenger or the prism of the music. Right? So the music flows through me and then out into the audience in an array of colors that touch people and affect them in whatever they need to be affected. So I'm just the prism. That's how I like to think about it.

MR: Excellent. Thank you for this, it's lovely listening to you talk and I'm sure I'm going to like the way you sing too. Did you have a question?

XX: I just had a question about whether you'd made it with the same band that you started out with or how you find a talent that will match yours you know?

AO: Well that's a good question. He knows about that. Well I actually have band members that I play with more than others because they are just there and they are amazing. But sometimes, depending on budget or depending on just curiosity even, with special guests and things like that, I might switch up something. Or if I'm playing on the west coast versus the east coast or if I'm traveling to another country, sometimes we're invited to do my repertoire but with the band that plays at a particular venue. I will say that my

guitarist is somebody that I had a senior recital, the guitarist I had did not learn the music, he didn't practice, he came, he showed up, he was terrible and then he blamed it on everybody. "This isn't my type of music." I'm like, "You just didn't practice." But my recital was like coming up in three days and you know, recitals are hard. Like I was pulling in classical music and jazz and I was freaking out. And someone said, "I know this great guitarist, he's amazing." I think he was like a sophomore. And I was like "Whatever, just bring him in here." And he was like okay, he took the music, he went away, he shed that music, he practiced, he showed up at the rehearsal and nailed it. And I was like, "Dude, you're going to be my American Express I'm never leaving home without you." Like anywhere I can go, if I can take you, I will take you. And so David, he's here tonight too with me. But I'd rather have no guitarist than be forced to play with like a bunch of other guitarists because he can't make it.

XX: And that's the way it is, too.

AO: Yeah. I'll be like I just won't have one.

MR: Wow. MVP.

AO: Yeah. And you'll hear why. You're all coming to the show, right? Okay.

MR: Thank you very much.

AO: Thank you.

MR: It was a real pleasure.